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Mutations of the emerging new globalization in the post-COVID-19 era: Beyond Rodrik's trilemma

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Abstract

Today's tensions and challenges at the global governance level seem to constitute structural expressions of the global system's mutations towards the post-COVID-19 era. This study examines whether the structural changes observed in various socio-economic dimensions and interdependent spatial levels due to the pandemic crisis are accelerating the emergence of a new phase of global governance. It investigates whether Rodrik's trilemma (the incompatibility of synchronously achieving national sovereignty, democracy, and globalization) seems to be relatively inadequate to approach today's emerging global reality and challenges comprehensively. After an elliptic overview of world governance's evolutionary shaping and reaching the present-day necessarily repositioned role of BRICS (Brazil-Russia-India-China-South Africa), we argue that these countries must no longer be perceived as emerging exceptional cases but as central participants, equally responsible for promoting a more balanced and sustainable development perspective for the less developed socio-economic formations and the entire global socio-economic system's stability. We conclude that in the progressively shaped "new globalization," which is a distinct evolutionary phase of the international economy and international relations, Rodrik's trilemma seems to some extent analytically insufficient since there is no more a sustainable optimum in any of its coupled dimensions, which could allow a viable exit from the current crisis.

Keywords: Global governance; BRICS; post-COVID-19 era; new globalization; global development, Rodrik's trilemma

1. Introduction

Amid the health and multidimensional socio-economic crisis of COVID-19 (hereafter pandemic), various cases reaffirm the ongoing rejection of formal international cooperation structures as relatively ineffective and allegedly insufficient to deal with the severe consequences of today's global destabilizing (Boylan et al., 2021). It increasingly seems that this criticism is directed with a new spirit towards the "new powerful centers" of the global economy and specifically towards BRICS (Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa). For example, in the early days of the pandemic outbreak, various populist rhetorics appeared worldwide that explicitly accused as the source of the problem the "Chinese virus" (Man, 2020). This fact undoubtedly shows that China's primarily growing economic and diplomatic influence is evident in various decision centers, which consider this rising power to create increased rifts in Western and US hegemony (Klinger, 2020). Scholars like Shaw (2021) also notice that the "destructive and anarchic unilateralism" like the one exercised recently by the Trump administration has been catalytic towards this direction. In this thread of events, global governance effectiveness for facing today's pressing health problems and economic, social, and geopolitical tensions has been further hindered (Dodds et al., 2020; Vériter et al., 2020).

Various facts reveal that the significant implication of the emergence of BRICS is the growing necessity for multilateral and multipolar global governance restructuring. Accounting now for more than 20% of global Gross Domestic Product (GDP), these countries advocate for

the idea that an urgent need to reconceptualize and reform the multilateral governance system is now emerging in a pressing manner (Siddiqui, 2016). More effective global governance, which means mainly enhanced political cooperation among different forms of transnational actors (public, private and mixed) to respond to problems that affect more than one region or nation-state, is a constant pursuit of BRICS (Cooper, 2017). Including the United Nations (UN), the World Trade Organization (WTO), the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and other international organizations, the group of BRICS claim that they will continue working to make the intergovernmental institutions more inclusive, democratic, and representative by shaping a fairer, more just, and more representative multipolar international order and global governance for the future (Brasília Declaration: 11th BRICS Summit, 2019).

These events are part of the broader repositioned problematique of global governance and international relations and the ways globalization is unfolding—or, even more accurately, seeking a new equilibrium nowadays—for the post-COVID-19 era (Gaillard, 2020; Hameiri, 2021). In the post-pandemic world, an outline of "chaos" and insecurity appears to prevail, in which the international community strives to give practical and holistic answers (Cole & Dodds, 2021). This article will attempt to clarify these issues by arguing that a "new globalization" is now in the formation stage, constituting, in this base, the conceptual canvas for studying all the related future global developments. To do so, it will examine specifically the famous trilemma brought forth by Rodrik (2011) that explains future globalization in a continuous and inescapable tension between democracy, national entities and global markets, which can only be remedied with three options. First, restriction of democracy to minimize international transaction costs by ignoring the socio-economic strains occasionally generated in the global system. Second, constrain globalization with the hope of achieving domestic democratic legitimacy and national integrity, and third, globalizing democracy at the expense of national sovereignty.

Observing the emergence of the "new globalization," one will find a deviation from the basic assumptions of the trilemma. This discrepancy can be noticed in the relevant literature that assumes that the new globalization is gaining ground today because it is an entirely new phase of the world socio-economic system—which any quasi-static trilemma cannot capture. For example, Baldwin (2012) notes that the new globalization is wilder and less equal than the old globalization, especially in more prosperous economies, requiring more openness and unprecedented policy effort to overcome the arising challenges. In a similar vein, Vlados (2019) suggests, by examining the evolution of the global economy after World War II (WWII), that "a new globalization" strives to take shape, already before the current pandemic crisis. Vlados (2019) stresses that this new globalization materializes nowadays—following the structural maturation of the early 2000s and the subsequent shock of 2008—at the co-evolution of the international regime's restructuration, the mutation of the underlying modes of development and crisis for the different socio-economic formations, and the profound transformation of the main types of innovational synthesis within the different value-production organizations at the global level.

This conceptual article will examine the related literature elliptically to propose a restructured theoretical reading of the global socio-economic system's current metamorphosis (Jaakkola, 2020). In this semi-systematic and qualitative exploration of the field (Snyder, 2019), different theoretical contributions, perspectives and framings will be examined, associated with recent COVID-19 implications in global socio-economic and political terms, a critical historical theorization of world governance and a re-comprehension of the famous Rodrik's trilemma. The goal is to shape in introductive terms a novel approach strafed towards the suggested emergence of a new phase of global evolution that we call "new globalization." Specifically, section two investigates various global-scale critical implications of today's structural rearrangements caused by COVID-19 on the economy, society, and politics. Section three deals with world governance's formation from a historical perspective and examines the current redeployed role of BRICS, emphasizing the ongoing dynamic transformation of informal means of global governance. Section four puts into perspective Rodrik's trilemma and offers a critique that functions as the substratum for hypothesizing the emergence of the new globalization. Section five concludes and offers final commentaries concerning the desired new course of the

global socio-economic system, namely the path of realistic and innovative liberalism at the global level, which we suggest as a redeployment of Fukuyama's (1992) "end of history," in the sense that it can constitute a vision towards the future and not a finalized form and static state.

2. COVID-19 has a severe impact on global socio-economic and political equilibria

Since the beginning of 2020 and the advent of COVID-19, the world has entered into an unprecedented restructuring. Anything that unfolds from now on will be the "post-COVID-19" era. The health crisis now seems to be causing the most severe economic downturn that humanity has experienced internationally in the last one hundred years. Numerous jobs in various industries were halted amid the need for health protection, while effectiveness and preparedness are pressing needs for all countries' health systems. According to António Guterres, Secretary-General of the UN (United Nations, 2020a), the pandemic crisis threatens the whole of humanity, and we must, as a global community, protect the most vulnerable, primarily women and children, the elderly and those with chronic diseases. Simultaneously, Guterres argues that we must not stop funding humanitarian programs to protect the world from the re-emergence of old diseases (cholera, measles, and meningitis), leading to starvation even more children and causing violent extremists to rise in power. All this can give extra space to the spread of the pandemic and the overall socio-economic consequences it causes.

Therefore, the message is clear: humanity faces a profound crisis nowadays, requiring new global workarounds instead of only nation-centric ones. The pandemic might have a severe impact both on the advanced and developing economies. The result will depend on the evolution of the crisis, the size of losses and damages, and the extent of the undertaken political measures. Simultaneously, the effectiveness of the relevant policies and socio-economic spillovers from the developed to the emerging socio-economic formations and markets seems necessary for facing the pandemic's direct socio-economic repercussions and reinforcing future development (Lam, 2021; Zaremba et al., 2021). On the pandemic's economic implications, a report by the World Bank (2020) concluded that COVID-19 caused a heavy blow to the global system and the most significant recession after WWII. Despite the extraordinary political support, the global recession will be the largest since WWII and even more profound if countries take longer to bring the pandemic under control. The health crisis will leave its mark on investor and consumer confidence and behavior, and policymakers need to, in addition to continuing with short-term measures to tackle the pandemic, design comprehensive programs to stimulate and improve the fundamental drivers of economic development and resilience. The revisions in forecasts that occurred amid the pandemic's first worldwide spread in the first half of 2020 revealed the global socio-economic system's uncharted waters nowadays. The World Economic Outlook (WEO), an annual report of the IMF (2020a, 2020b) that analyzes macroeconomic and other data from the monitoring of economic growth and policies in its member states, revised in June 2020 its forecast of April 2020 by estimating that global growth will fall by 4.9%, 1.9 percentage points less than the earlier forecast. Referring to a crisis like no other so far, the WEO argued that there could only be uncertainty in the forecasts we can make due to the quarantine period, the subsequent voluntary social distancing, the displaced workers, and the security measures. The WEO predicted that China would slowly recover, while Latin America and India will contract after the widespread lockdown.

The projections of the International Labor Organization (ILO) are also discouraging. In the 2020 report of June, ILO (2020) pointed out that working-hour losses have increased since May. The ILO argued that the factors leading to this loss of working hours are temporary leave or permanent unemployment and inactivity. As a result, the ILO noticed that a close focus on the phenomenon of unemployment could not help assess the pandemic's impact on the labor market and, accordingly, the development of policy solutions. The report implied that more comprehensive solutions are needed to map unemployment based on these depressing figures' structural causes instead of superficial ones.

On the impact of the pandemic on society and politics, various instances indicate that new and worrying challenges are rising. Various national governments across the world were forced

to postpone, suspend, or cancel democratic elections at both sub-national and national governmental levels, a development that challenges the very nature of democracy since it contradicts the idea of successive governmental terms that take place in the more advanced democratic regimes (International Institute for Democracy and Electoral Assistance, 2020). This concern becomes even more pressing considering the apparent regression in the field of human rights. The UN (2020) accordingly reported that the unfolding crisis appears as the basis for promoting repressive measures unrelated to the pandemic, primarily due to rising authoritarianism, populism, and nationalism, leading to discrimination against specific communities, xenophobia, mistreatment of migrants, and sexual and gender-based violence. Media freedom pushbacks have also contributed to this new turbulent global environment. Various press freedom restrictions have been reported during the pandemic, with multiple governments introducing new legislation to prevent the spread of misinformation and protect the governmental power from being poorly represented. As reported by the European Parliamentary Research Service (2020), in China and Russia, two countries that strict media censorship laws were already in place, the pandemic offered an opportunity for further restrictions on media freedom. The pandemic's ramifications on promoting democracy and human freedom have been multifaceted (Haagh, 2020). In this context, we highlight the emerging challenges of global governance, with the pandemic crisis bringing to the surface questions regarding even the need to sustain ideologies committed to a democratic and open society and liberalism (Levy, 2021).

Amid the pandemic, vaccine nationalism also is recorded as a fundamental symptom of a rising "new nationalism," referring to various countries' efforts to access the supply of vaccines and potentially hoard vital components for vaccine production (Eaton, 2021). The Global Alliance for Vaccines and Immunization (GAVI, 2021) calculated the immense cost of the poorest countries staying out of COVID-19 vaccination, arguing that equal access would generate significant benefits in global GDP. The ongoing drastically reframed national introversion context has led various international relations scholars to worrying converging diagnoses concerning worldwide cooperation and coordination to combat this global health and socio-economic crisis. Specific points of focus are related to the deepening turmoil in the relationships between the US, China and Russia (and the BRICS by extension) since the pandemic is not treated as a common enemy but a ground for controversy and potential impositions (Zhao, 2021).

In broad terms and at all levels of the socio-economic environment, the new post-COVID-19 era that unfolds seems to have brought a structural reconfiguration. The pandemic has led to the world's most significant post-WWII recession and socio-economic turbulence, which seems hardly possible to be surpassed soon in global and cross-spatial terms. Such challenges are the temporary halt of various jobs and employment (a phenomenon which under certain conditions can acquire permanent characteristics for various less resilient socio-economic formations on the planet), the steep fall of global GDP and anemic growth rates, and the nation-centric pressures followed by the worsening of conditions at the political dialogue climate (see the actual regression of specific democratic structures across the world with the parallel restriction of human rights and liberties in various cases).

In this context, everything leads to the need for a repositioned spirit and framework for managing the newly emerging cross-national and global reality. Therefore, Rodrick's trilemma—which is structured as the incompatibility of synchronously achieving national sovereignty, democracy development, and further participation in globalization—does not appear sufficient to offer an integrated framework for understanding the post-COVID-19 challenges. On first reading, Rodrik's trilemma seems ineffective as the horizon for a nation to structure a successful choice since a setback can be observed to all the trilemmatic analytical dimensions. Globalization's trends seem to be slowing down with the unprecedented recession and turmoil in international trade, the relevance of narrow national sovereignty agendas is being reassessed, and democratic institutions are challenged due to the reinforcement of authoritarianism in various cases across the world, even in developed economies (Fuchs, 2021). Even more, we doubt whether the "golden rule" of picking "two out of three" would suffice as

a recipe for exiting the crisis, both for the different national entities (more or less powerful) and for the global system altogether.

Overall, we think that a new and broader perspective is needed to approach the questions raised above as comprehensively as possible: are there global governance institutions and mechanisms sufficient for promoting and guaranteeing a new sustainable global development trajectory in the post-COVID-19 era, and especially considering the new significance the BRICS receive within the global system? The following section examines this question elliptically.

3. Global governance restructuration and the emerging new role of BRICS

In the recent scholarly literature, international cooperation and global governance's enhancement are considered the primary diodes for addressing the post-COVID-19 issues (Bishop & Payne, 2021; Carayannis & Weiss, 2021). In this section, global governance's critical milestones are examined, arriving at today's emerging new role the BRICS play in global governance.

3.1. Global governance in a historical perspective

Before identifying the different forms of global governance, it is worth mentioning that we acknowledge the limitations of examining the history of International Relations (IR) in a scientific paper, which can lead to omitting significant phases of development before the twentieth century. Scholars have attempted over the past years to reexamine the context of historicizing international relations (de Carvalho et al. (2011) constitute a notable example), arguing that IR cannot escape the "myths" of 1648 (Peace of Westphalia) and 1919 (birth of the discipline out of the calamities of the First World War (WWI)). Therefore, a common starting ground for understanding the history of global governance is usually found in the Peace of Westphalia, which affirmed state sovereignty as the primary governing principle and the building block of European order after the Thirty Years' War, instead of the empire, dynasty, or religious confession (Philpott, 2010). The Westphalian concept that favored the establishment of sovereignty conceived multiplicity and the presence of multiple societies at its core, theretofore searching for order among these societies that were now a reality (Kissinger, 2014). International law developed by traveling scholars-advisors during the Thirty Years' War was received as an adjustable and expandable body of agreed doctrine directed at the cultivation of peace by having at its center the Westphalian treaties themselves. Moving forward, another significant turning point of international relations under the rule of law is also the French and American revolutions of the late eighteenth century, where the principle of government is affirmed and distinguished from the governance, namely a form of administration that can act within the boundaries of the constitution for the interests of popular sovereignty (Lopez-Claros et al., 2020). Overall, it is argued that this international system formulated by the Peace of Westphalia and by the later constitutionalism is after the twentieth century the stage upon which today's world functions (Kreuder-Sonnen & Zangl, 2015).

A brief description of the successive phases in the international system's structuration is presented in Table 1. This categorization distinguishes six periods.

Table 1: Distinct phases of world governance structures

	The core of international relations in different periods
Pre-WWI international economy (1648-1919)	Peace of Westphalia and formation of international law
Interwar international economy (1919-1945)	The rise and decline of the League of Nations era
Post-WWII international economy (1945-1973)	The establishment of the post-WWII bipolarity (Cold War) and the US hegemony
The pre-globalization economy (1973-1980)	The shock of the post-WWII international regime after the 1970s oil crises
Globalization (1980-2008)	The development of the post-Cold War era, with the rise of BRICS
The quest for the new globalization (2008-)	Searching for new multipolar global governance (realistic and innovative global liberalism)

The early twentieth century and post-WWI period mark the other significant milestone in international relations, in which world governance takes a definitive shape. Inspired by President Woodrow Wilson amid WWI, the League of Nations operated as an international body that included all the then leading forces to prevent war conflicts (Goodrich, 1947). However, the taking of only unanimous decisions and the inexistence of mechanisms for implementing or enforcing those decisions were inherent problems of this organization. After the economic boom of the 1920s, intensely protective and nation-centric forces appeared in the 1930s, more durable than those leading up to WWI, with the League being in practice powerless to impose any peaceful settlement and economic stability (Eloranta, 2011). The atrocities of the ensuing WWII led to the need to reposition international cooperation. After lengthy consultations during the war, the UN finally arose from the San Francisco conference in 1945, offering clauses that could help avoid the League's earlier weaknesses. The UN Charter allowed the right to veto security issues only to the four great powers (US, UK, USSR, China, with France later added) while making solid references to the promotion of human rights, as opposed to the League (Sobel, 1994).

In economic terms, the designing of the post-WWII monetary system of fixed rates delivered autonomy for national policies and international financial stability. The Bretton Woods system had general rules which the governments had to follow and various significant focal points. Firstly, to promote the liberalization of trade through multilateral negotiations inspired by the principle of non-discrimination. Secondly, transactions falling within the current account would not be subject to controls, although allowing controls on the freedom of movement of capital. Thirdly, exchange rates had to be stable or locked and that, while a nation could change the exchange rate of its currency, it had to consult the IMF before making significant changes (Gilpin, 2000).

In this period, the post-WWII international economy ran under the geopolitically hierarchical sum of the countries involved in the expanding international trade. The large and developed states of the "capitalist center" had a vital role in managing global affairs, with the US being the undisputed leader of this cross-national capitalist economy. The "capitalist periphery" countries followed without any friction their co-dependent course (Bordo & Flandreau, 2003). In this context, foreign direct investment abroad, international capital flows, and international technology transfer were still taking place on a small scale. The shift and transfer of production capacity from one country to another had, at this time, a minor and complementary character to the functioning of the world economy (Nunnenkamp, 2002). The national entities were the dominant players, while production factors (labor, capital, natural resources, technology, and entrepreneurship) remained "tied" to their domestic base.

In the early 1970s, this phase of the international economy entered a transformational crisis. First, the oil crisis of 1973, then that of 1979, accompanied by the persistent reproduction of stagflation, showed that the earlier development regime was now outdated (Rogers, 2013). Initially, the crisis occurred within the central socio-economic systems, with intense and persistent inflationary pressures followed by a significant unemployment increase (stagflation). Simultaneously, various firms based in developed Western countries faced a drastic squeeze of their profits that caused the reduction of new investment and the halt of the pace of economic

growth. In the background, this crisis destabilized and redefined the world economy of the time, causing three changes (Vlados, 2019):

i. The fixed exchange rate system lifted, and the dollar's conversion to gold stopped by recording significant devaluation.
ii. The Vietnam War shook the US "hegemony" in military, ideological, and economic terms.
iii. "Fordism"[1] and the Western development model entered a crisis, both at the level of mass production and consumption; the welfare state faced increasing problems as stagflation became permanent, with the standard tools of the Keynesian regulation appearing in practice less and less efficient.

This phase also sparked an interest in a new form of global governance, which began with globalization's emergence (Benería, 2003). When the US economic power started facing a significant upset due to the oil crises in the 1970s and the aftermath of the Vietnam War losses, the Group of Seven (G7) began to function as a club with a significant role in decision-making in global issues. Following the first informal summit in France in 1975, the participants (US, UK, Japan, Germany, Italy, France, and later Canada) set up this meeting as a forum for discussing issues of global governance, economic development, international trade, and cooperation (for example, within the framework of the WTO). From 1997 to 2014, Russia's participation before its expulsion due to Crimea's annexation gave these meetings—which were characterized by a fair degree of informality—the title "Group of Eight" (Prodi, 2016).

Since then, informal bodies did not stop to proliferate and gain increased influence. The Commission on Global Governance (1995) offers a thorough explanation of the informality phenomenon, suggesting that governance is a continuing process including diverse and conflicting interests between private and public actors, both individuals and institutions. Based on this reasoning, sovereign nations take part now in an interdependent world of formal regimes and institutions vested with the power to enforce compliance together with informal arrangements that individuals and institutions have committed to or believe are in their interests. According to the profound conclusions of the Commission on Global Governance report, global governance is about establishing a "global neighborhood understanding" of our shared future that requires above all a "global civic ethic" as the foundation upon which all rules and institutions can be built (Mani, 2015). However, concerning the specific case of the growing number and power of informal international organizations created by the states over the past years, it can be noted that this development has contributed to the growing re-polarization in global governance and, consequently, that most of them appear incapable of addressing today's complex challenges (Roger, 2020).

Informal institutions are primarily rooted in the idea of soft law, with the recent health emergency caused by the pandemic being a typical successful example of cooperation between public and private actors (Hattke & Martin, 2020; Sampat & Shadlen, 2021). Soft law in this context means that the public sector is not the only one responsible for enacting the rules, allowing social actors to bargain inside a broader policy statement (Røiseland et al., 2011). These hybrid governance structures have led to the flourishing of various organizations of mixed public-private ownership, with the very national governments increasingly pursuing ways to make their administrative systems more business-driven and with the private enterprises searching for value gains in promoting the public interest through their corporate responsibility policies (Vakkuri & Johanson, 2020).[2] In this context, concerning specifically

[1] Fordism is a concept used to characterize the post-WWII development of Western nations. It describes the cycle of mass production and consumption, the creation of standardized (most often) consumer products sold in (usually) protected domestic markets, and the use of Keynesian economic policies. The French regulation theory refers to different national modes of growth (accumulation and regulation regimes) to show distinct varieties of Fordism in Western economies (Boyer & Saillard, 2005).

[2] Apart from soft-law implications, the third industrial revolution has led to the immense rise of information technology networks already from the earlier phase of globalization that, amid the unfolding fourth industrial revolution, are transforming into cyber-physical systems, where the digital and physical worlds progressively become blurred (Schwab, 2016). In this sophisticated and interconnected business

the case of the informal global institution of G7, it should be noted that the foundation that initially brought these states together primarily was the "Western concept of the world," in the sense of supporting institutions to safeguard and strengthen international trade and liberal democracy. These informal summits are ways to meet common interests through face-to-face meetings (Bailin, 2017) and, despite advertising the egalitarian nature of these meetings between the most industrialized states on the planet, the US hegemony has been evident (Bayne, 1997).

Overall, the post-WWII international regime constructed official international institutions such as the UN, the Bretton Wood system, the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade, and the World Trade Organization (WTO). Although these structures gave the least developed countries a degree of access to decision-making mechanisms, they remained markedly hierarchical, reflecting the US's hegemonic role. However, as conditions gradually change, with emerging economies gathering increased political shares internationally, participation has risen in these international clubs. At the same time, new informal global governance institutions continue to appear and challenge the formal institutions and rearrange world politics (Westerwinter et al., 2021). In today's change of the global system and the emergence of the new globalization, the reformatted role of the informal group of BRICS seems increasingly transformative. The following sub-section examines synoptically the new place and role this group of countries progressively picks up in this restructured socio-economic environment.

3.2. The new role of BRICS

During the globalized phase of the economy (1980 and beyond), one of the transition milestones in global equilibrium was undoubtedly the dynamic rise of BRICS. The world's developing countries grew swiftly during this period, with the BRICS occupying the highest relative shares. Figure 1 illustrates the evolution of real GDP growth, where the BRICS recorded a significant increase in the 2000s, much higher than the worldwide GDP rate. Even today, the growth of BRICS seems to be moving faster than other countries.

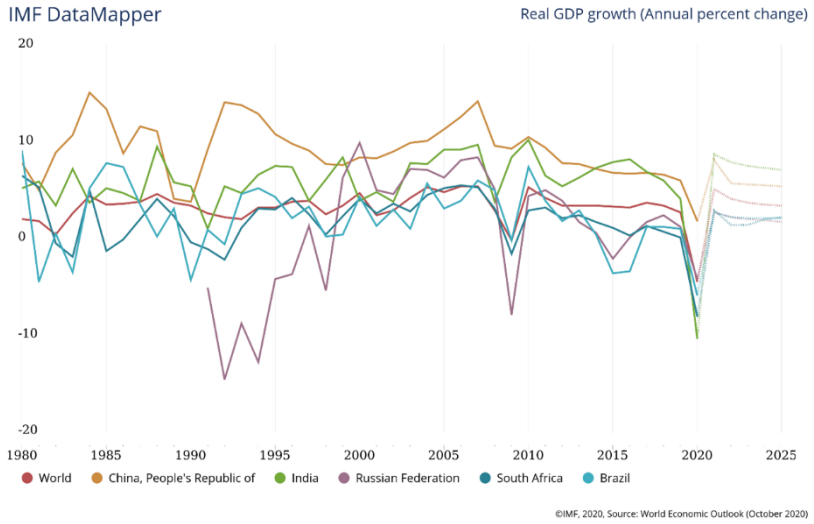


Figure 1: Real GDP growth for BRICS and the world. 2025 projection. Source: IMF (2020c).

Concerning the history of this growth, China's example deserves special mention. In particular, the Chinese economy before the 1980s was almost insignificant, in global terms, and then took off in an impressive way and velocity, without following the "Washington Consensus" recipes (Rodrik, 2006). Its leadership used various policy tools designed to expand and increase the existing industrial structures rapidly. These policies were in direct conflict with

and governing environment, as Kelly (1999) noticed already in the late nineties, the world of the soft (the intangibles and all other services) appears to command the world of the hard.

WTO conventional rules, which prohibit export subsidies and discrimination in favor of domestic companies (Blancher & Rumbaugh, 2004). This "Chinese miracle" was primarily due to the Special Economic Zones, which functioned as exporting engines and foreign investment attractors. The firms in the zones ran under different rules than those in force for the rest of the country, having access to better infrastructure and the ability to import what they needed, duty-free, from abroad (Yeung et al., 2009). Also, institutional innovations transformed China's production rapidly. Even though low labor costs helped in this exporting orientation, foreign investors also played a crucial role in China's industrial mutation. These were the most productive companies and a constant source of competitive potential and source (Fung et al., 2004). China managed to make a drastic opening to foreign companies while protecting its domestic markets to attract investors looking for a large consumer market and not just those looking to reduce their costs through cheap labor. China finally became a member of the WTO only in 2001—in the meantime, it had managed to create a solid industrial base. Thus, it significantly reduced its tariffs, preparing for WTO membership, moving from the elevated levels of the early 1990s (40% on average) to single-digit rates in 2001. Therefore, China began to rely on a competitive exchange rate to offer indirect protection to its industrial sectors by intervening in foreign exchange markets and keeping its borders closed to speculative capital inflows. In this way, its past direct industrial policies gave way to indirect support through monetary policy (Hemphill & White, 2013; Walmsley et al., 2006).

Nowadays, it seems that—also based on the pandemic's accelerating influence—we are entering into a new multipolar regime of global governance that incubates a new role for the BRICS (Petrone, 2019). In this context, we must consider how the dynamics of cooperation between these countries transform today's global governance structurally. According to Bratersky (2020), the BRICS agree on setting up a multipolar world by following the UN Charter's collective security system by improving the international system's cooperation and stability. However, the way BRICS perceive multipolarity varies from country to country and in their foreign policy. This fact makes the multilateral diplomacy of BRICS fragile and relatively unstable, as non-Western claims are the group's underlying motives (Dutta, 2019). However, their actions on the innovation-enhancing front can play a vital role in the foreseeable future (BRICS 10th Summit Johannesburg Declaration, 2018). In 2014, the BRICS signed a memorandum of understanding to develop multilateral cooperation at the levels of science, technology, and innovation to adapt to the global environment (Kiselev & Nechaeva, 2018). This fact shows that all BRICS countries can gain an advantage from their cooperation and improve their global competitive position, despite China's leadership (Sidorova, 2018). A crucial aspect of this evolutionary path will be how they will manage to move from a development model based on raw material overexploitation and massive economies of scale to a model of innovation intensity and quality upgrade in the newly emerging fourth industrial revolution (Vlados & Chatzinikolaou, 2020).

In terms of economic development, if we consider cooperation combined with creating global governance institutions, the BRICS group could have an essential new role in the years to come (Viswanathan & Soni, 2017). However, these countries also have structural weaknesses, which prevent the full and fertile integration of this formation into global governance. As Brosig (2019) mentions, the BRICS are not an implementing agency. They have no secretariat or headquarters and are not a strategic alliance like the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO). Therefore, its members must follow the existing multilateral institutions such as the UN and other regional organizations. Also, as they are diverse, they do not address internal security issues when they make only exceptional remarks about external peacekeeping concerns. For example, they do not thoroughly discuss the border dispute between India and China or between Pakistan and India (both nuclear powers). Brosig (2019) adds that BRICS may lose in the future their normative power over the West if they do not provide institutionalization in the security besides the economic sphere, such as with the New Development Bank. Therefore, while a growing number of analysts are treating the phenomenon of BRICS from the perspective of the declining US hegemony and Western institutions (Chaturvedi & Saha, 2019; Menegazzi, 2020), we can see a higher degree of complexity in this issue. The BRICS have deepened multipolar international cooperation on

global governance issues, strengthening peacekeeping and security structures internationally. However, the BRICS should take other cases of building a central institution in the emerging new polycentric world as an example, such as the European Union (Maslova & Entin, 2019). In other words, they should quickly and efficiently assimilate elements of strengthening democratic institutions and human rights within their national regimes.

There is no doubt that we were already experiencing a transition to global governance before the pandemic, especially after the financial collapse of 2008 and the subsequent increasing participation of BRICS in the world arena (Andreou et al., 2017). However, BRICS's repositioning poses a systemic challenge in today's world. For example, climate change and nuclear proliferation are two threats that the global political community must address in a coordinated manner (Alexandroff & Cooper, 2010). Immediate solutions to these issues cannot exist amid the weakening of official international institutions, especially considering that existing global governance institutions are on the sidelines of dispute resolution (see the US-China trade war; Vlados, 2020).

It can be concluded that nowadays (and in terms of future developments), the BRICS's role must be profoundly restructured. Until now, the BRICS were the quasi-"paradoxical" emerging protagonists of global developments with their prolonged lightning-fast growth rates during the last phase of globalization, while today, the question is how these countries, through a different type of global governance, could form islets that function towards enhancing stability and diffusing development in other nations severely hit by the pandemic. BRICS should no longer be seen as an exceptional case that creates impressive results within globalization; they constitute an already central established reality, highly responsible for the global socio-economic system's overall future management. The question from then on is not how these quickly growing players can be reconsidered only from an aggregative perspective in terms of their contribution to the global economy but how they can take over a significant share of responsibility to actively engage to a new sustainable global model of governance and development. The problem, from then on, is how they can actively and structurally participate in the construction of effective polycentric leadership (Hou, 2013) in the new requirements brought forth by the "new globalization" that takes shape at present, especially when cooperation is further needed in strategic health and specific socio-economic projects (da Silva Jr. et al., 2014).

Overall, the global reality drastically changes because the central issue is profoundly transpositioned: to how the developed Western nations could regain a robust development dynamic after the great recession that they dealt with in 2020 and 2021, and how a developmental trajectory could also be restored for the less developed and less resilient countries. "Paradoxically," in the context of this new global economy and society, it seems that these newly established "great powers" of BRICS must function as central motors for promoting a more equilibrated and inclusive global development by simultaneously striving for enhanced democratic institutions, readjusted national sovereignty, and further openness to the global market, economy, and society. We appreciate that this understanding makes from now on Rodrik's trilemma relatively fragile and interpretatively insufficient, and we intend to examine the specifics of this argument in the next section.

4. Towards the new globalization and the reexamination of Rodrik's trilemma

One of the fundamental theoretical instruments that we have at our perceptual arsenal to interpret the formation of effective socio-economic trajectories at the global level is Dani Rodrik's "paradox of globalization" approach. In terms of global governance, Rodrik (2011, p. 232) notices the interconnection between private and public actors, focusing on the fact that their political identities nowadays are mostly the outcome of local processes:

> "*The new forms of global governance are intriguing and deserve further development, but ultimately they run up against some fundamental limits: political identities and attachments still revolve around nation states; political communities are organized domestically rather than globally; truly global norms have emerged only in a narrow range of issues; and there remain substantial differences across the world on desirable*

institutional arrangements. … We need to accept the reality of a divided world polity and make some tough choices. We have to be explicit about where one nation's rights and responsibilities end and another nation's begin. We cannot fudge the role of nation states and proceed on the assumption that we are witnessing the birth of a global political community. … Hyperglobalization cannot be achieved, and we should not pretend that it can."

The primary problem deriving from Rodrik's analysis is the alleged pursuance of achieving a hypothetical optimum, expressed as "hyperglobalization" (Anheier & Filip, 2021). Essentially, Rodrik argues that the global economy managed to develop before WWII amid a "golden straitjacket" situation (Friedman, 1999), characterized by a parallel pursuit of hyperglobalization and national sovereignty reinforcement. In the aftermath of the war, following recipes of Keynesian inspiration, the "Bretton Woods compromise" was achieved at the expense of promoting hyperglobalization and enhancing the nation-centric contour of economic development. In the years that followed, democracy worked exceptionally within the national context and boundaries, in which socio-economic activity inevitably started to "overflow" in multinational directions. As a result, globalization has been a fact since the early 1980s, leading, according to Rodrik, to a series of paradoxes based on a so-called "trilemma" in which always, as a global economy, we can pick only two of the three available options. We can either choose the golden straitjacket option or a readjustment of the Bretton Woods compromise, or a global governance scenario that surpasses national boundaries for building the international institutions' global sovereignty. Overall, Rodrik (2011, p. 206) suggests we are inevitably heading towards a more limited version of globalization by redeploying the dimensions of national sovereignty and democracy (Figure 2):

"*The world economy has since been trapped in an uncomfortable zone between the three nodes of the trilemma. … We have no choice but to settle for a 'thin' version of globalization—to reinvent the Bretton Woods compromise for a different era. … We cannot simply bring back wholesale the approaches of the 1950s and 1960s. We will have to be imaginative, innovative, and willing to experiment.*"

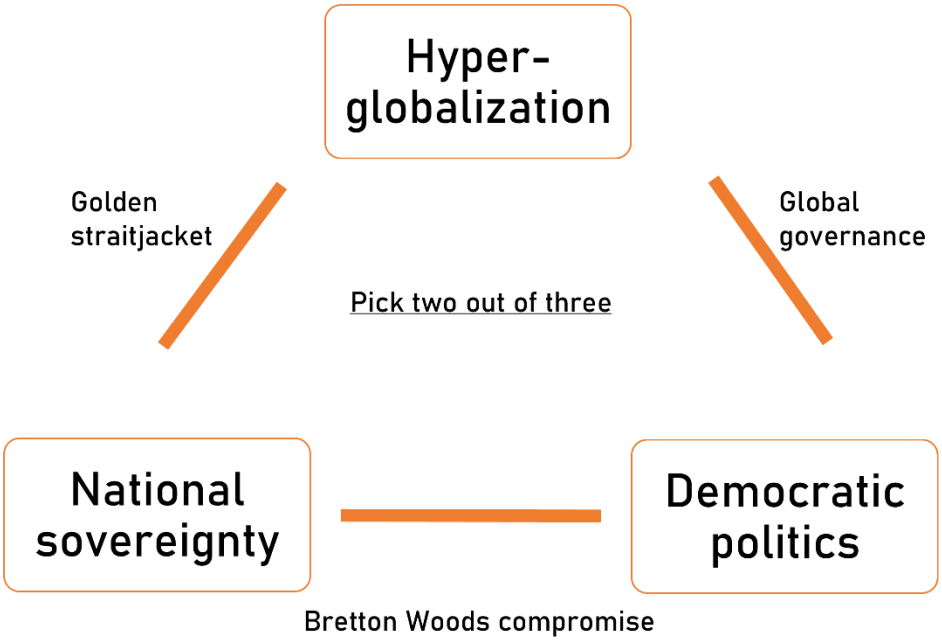


Figure 2: Rodrik's trilemma. Based on Rodrik (2011).

Rodrik's approach does not seem to focus on the appearance of the newly emerging global reality that has been incubated during the earlier phase of globalization. Today's emerging global system is at a tipping point (the post-COVID-19 era), which determines the transition towards a qualitatively different new global equilibrium of dynamics, leading to the emergence

of a novel multipolar regime. In this newly materializing global system, the BRICS seem that they have from now on to play a vital role on the geopolitical and geo-economic "world chessboard," where new forms of informal governance will have a gradually central position within the global system's regulation and coordination.

Within the strict boundaries of Rodrik's trilemma, globalization is indeed in a paradox. However, the approach fails because it examines the three "incompatible" dimensions of national sovereignty, democracy, and globalization as "fully-blown," according to Stein (2016). To this end, Stein (2016) concludes an analysis of Rodrik's trilemma by acknowledging the inevitable negative effect of politics on all three sides of the triangle due to this incompatibility. The approach of Hale et al. (2014) seems to be much closer to the emergence of a new system nowadays, arguing that global governance appears to be failing when we need it most, confined within a "gridlock." However, even this gridlock only emphasizes the increasing institutionalization after WWII that led to greater interdependence, which led to greater institutionalization and interdependence in turn (in a self-reinforcing cycle). The bottom line of the gridlock is that global governance today is (as expected) ineffective. In our times, we must draw the line between the old and the new system by escaping the trilemmas and "gridlocks." This under-construction worldwide system requires support at the global governance level, meaning greater participation, increased cohesion, and more democracy. If we look at the historical shaping of the international economy, we can leave the trilemmas and gridlocks to the past, directing the potential towards the emergence of a "new globalization."

Having studied the change in the correlation of power in global governance, we can conclude that today's reality favors an overall shift in all symbiotic socio-economic dimensions instead of a "trilemma." This shift rearranges the structures of both cooperation and competition, combined with the necessarily reestablished role of state intervention, the active participation of civil society, and the multiple informal mechanisms of regulation and governance. After all, in this interconnected world, it seems that the co-opetition strategy (Brandenburger & Nalebuff, 1996) has a lot also to offer at the geopolitical level because the prospect of different competitors working together rather than going up against each other seems increasingly critical (Vlados et al., 2019). This can also be one of the outcomes of the current health crisis, which has brought more competition between nation-states while reinforcing the need for cooperation. Within this reframed context, private actors (and mostly mixed public-private actors) seem to be gaining increasing significance in this new globalization phase.

Therefore, it seems that there is no trilemma anymore but an entirely new frame of challenges in the new phase of the world economy, the "new globalization." Following a structural analysis, we appreciate that our world is currently at a crossroads that will inevitably lead to a new global system. In this context, based on the idea that the tipping point can describe "*an event that suffices to achieve a particular outcome, or an aspect of such an event, or the time of such an event"* (Carmichael et al., 2019, p. 83), it can be said that two fundamental, contrasted and combined at the same time, interpretive perspectives exist for understanding the global system's evolution: the conjunctural and the structural (Vlados, Deniozos, Chatzinikolaou, et al., 2018). The primary interpretive feature of conjunctural crises is that they create a case of emergency, an exogenous disorder, abnormal and occasional reversal of equilibrium, and a belief that the existing system can absorb the effects. In the second interpretive horizon, the less evident structural crisis is reproduced as an expected evolution in the sense that sooner or later will arrive since it is an endogenous restructuring, being a normal and organic readjustment of equilibrium that ultimately leads to the emergence of an entirely new system[3]. A new equilibrium is always born in their intersection, where a minor structural change is enough in the crucial point phase to move the system altogether (Figure 3).

[3] According to the Director-General of the World Health Organization, there can be "no return to normal" since the pandemic has transformed the way we live altogether (Adhanom, 2020).

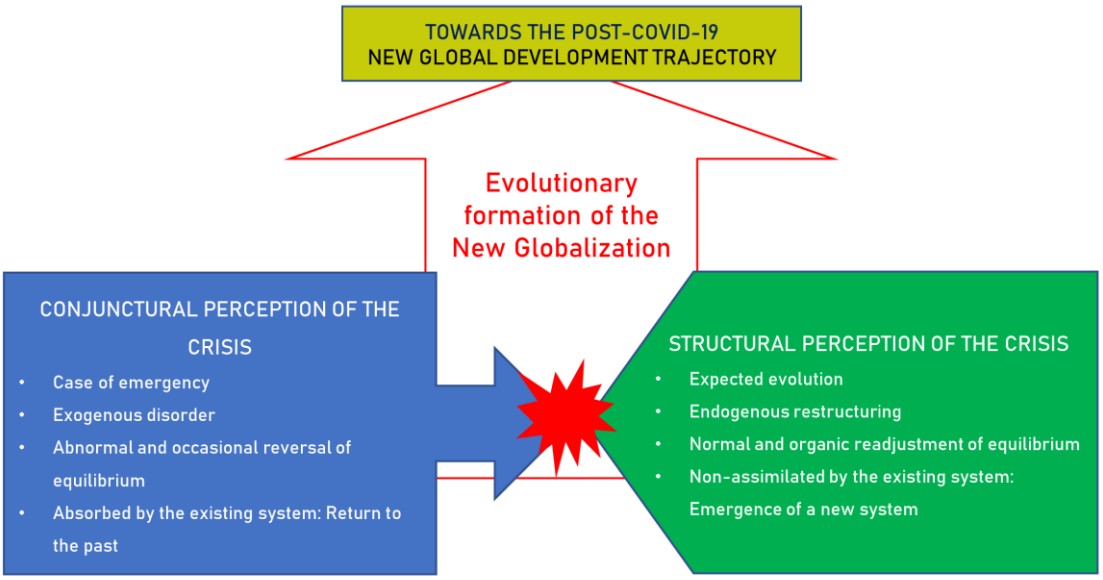


Figure 3: Nowadays, the world system seems structurally mutated, heading towards the post-COVID-19 new global development trajectory.

Therefore, new globalization is the system that seems to be surfacing nowadays, where both the concepts of competition and cooperation are profoundly redefined and repositioned at the international and global level, creating new challenges and new threats but also new opportunities (Vlados, 2019). These threats always appear where the system is comparatively weaker, whereas opportunities will be formulated upon the comparative strengths (Vlados & Chatzinikolaou, 2019). The appearing dimensions from the field of threats seem to primarily concern the possible failure of the already-developed Western societies to quickly recover from the economic damage caused by the pandemic and the increased likelihood that many of the less developed socio-economic systems will be trapped in a perspective of weak development prospects.[4] In case such threats shape up, it is highly possible that, over the next decade, various forms of social and geopolitical tensions might be manifested in different places across the world, leading to many old foci of conflict being rekindled and new ones to be created. However, a new opportunity might also be formulated in the post-COVID-19 era if new multipolar global governance and cooperation institutions (both formal and informal) manage to consolidate a really fruitful dialogue, communication, and coordination of new quality, succeeding in overturning the relatively restrictive view proposed in Rodrik's trilemma. This would allow (but also require from them) different socio-economic systems to simultaneously maintain and develop their democratic institutions and redefine their national sovereignty priorities from a repositioned perspective, inserting themselves into a restructured overall global development path.

5. Conclusions: The sought-after path of the new globalization and the realistic and innovative liberalism

Until today, it can be said that most BRICS countries have followed a path of pursuing hyperglobalization and enhanced national sovereignty. The primary example is China (although this is not the only case; see, for example, Russia, India, and the other BRICS), which seems to have distanced itself (until now) from emphasizing the structuration, development, and enhancement of democratic institutions. From a similar perspective, other Western countries have tried to maintain a course of developing and deepening their democratic institutions,

[4] "Nike swoosh" and "L-type" development perspective (Beech, 2020; Gómez-Pineda, 2020; Gregory et al., 2020).

increasingly opening themselves to the dynamics of globalization (the case of the European Union) and thereby progressively diminishing to some extent their emphasis on traditional national sovereignty terms. Finally, other countries tried to reinforce their national and democratic sovereignty by limiting their openness to globalization and expanding their rationale towards repositioned nation-centric management and trade protectionism. Can these models nowadays continue to exist as sustainable development paths in the new globalization? We do not think so (as we argued throughout this text).

On the contrary, we think it is also necessary for the BRICS (and all nations worldwide and irrespectively of their size and level of development) to deepen their democratic institutions and internally strengthen pluralism and human rights. Also, a requirement for various geopolitical actors of today's world, such as the US and the EU, is to rethink their national sovereignty ideas and policies, although continuing to open themselves to the newly restructured world economy and society. At the same time, countries that have chosen to date the diptych of national sovereignty and the development of international institutions must be encouraged to decidedly open themselves to the new form of globalization.

"Paradoxically," a common path to the future now seems to be required for all idiomorphic players worldwide, which poses similar challenges for all protagonists and followers: and this is a new "homogenizing" trend that emerges within an ever-increasing "heterogenizing" world after the pandemic. In this sense, the "end of history" by Fukuyama (1992, p. xi) seems capable of receiving a "paradoxical" update, even though we do not claim that the post-COVID-19 era will be the end-point of "*mankind's ideological evolution and the final form of human government*," with the alleged universalization of Western liberal democracy. This prediction has never been confirmed, nor do we think it can be materialized in the future. However, Fukuyama's perspective has a virtue that can prove constructive for tomorrow's developments: the need for a shared liberal path for all, both for the Third, the First, and the Second world (as Fukuyama would argue) and the greater or smaller, the mature or emerging, and the less developed or more developed socio-economic systems (as we argue).

These are the terms in which the new globalization's outline seems to be surfacing nowadays, bringing forth new priorities for all national and global socio-economic formations in the post-COVID-19 era. In this new global historical phase, the challenges of resilience and environmental sustainability become matters of urgency. Also, it seems that the best remedy for alleviating poverty is not based on pursuing superficial and short-lived growth, but it requires a structural socio-economic transformation that would allow long-term development. Additionally, the best treatment for dealing with inequality cannot lie in "exogenous aid" but in the systematic reinforcement of equal development opportunities for all humans and societies. Equally important, the hindering of extreme financial speculation might require a new regulatory framework on a global scale. At the same time, the reinforcement of freedom and civic rights on any society can only derive from the restructuring of state intervention, focusing thenceforth on improving the development and innovation potential. Finally, the protection of tolerance and pluralism based on the respective action of our societies is a condition *sine qua non* for variety and heterogeneity to be further preserved and cultivated across the world.

As it seems, these priorities could be synthesized in what we call the new, realistic, and innovative global liberalism, which poses a challenge to all global governance actors, irrespectively of their type and extent (Figure 4).

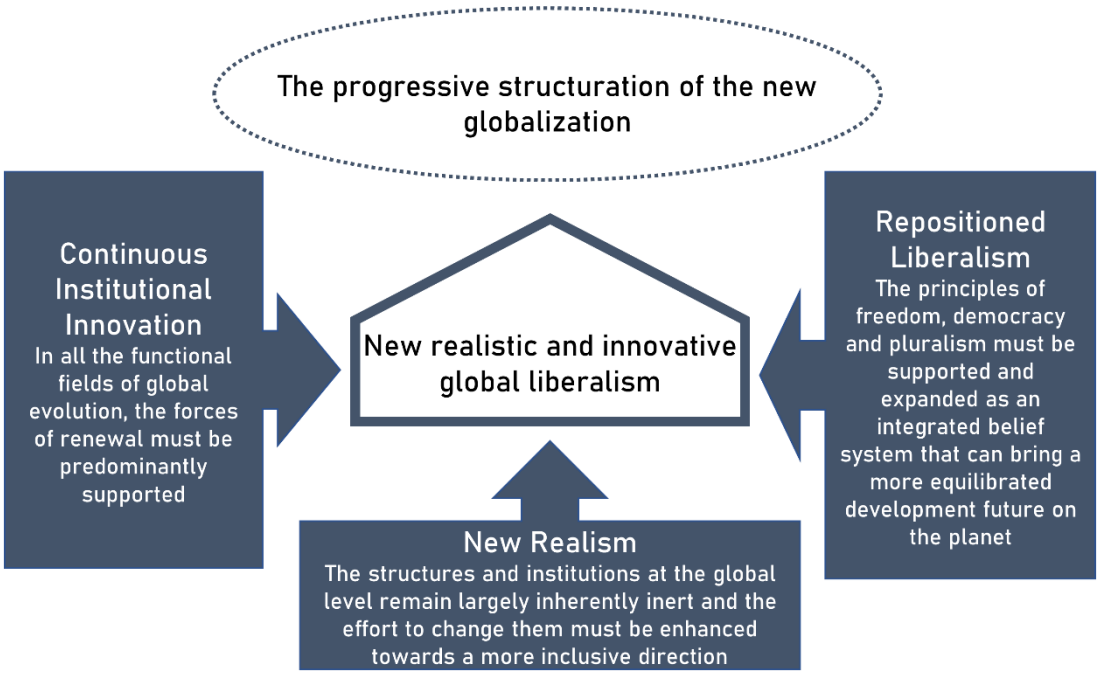


Figure 4: Towards the new globalization's progressive structuration upon the new realistic and innovative global liberalism. Based on Vlados et al. (2018).

We would describe this novel ideological-political horizon as "realistic and innovative global liberalism." In practice, we suggest a new way of viewing the global dynamic that manages to place proper emphasis on all synthesizing parts and simultaneously fertilize them. Realistic, in the sense that it becomes understood that the structures and institutions at the global level are inherently inert and that the resistance to change still is substantial, and the effort to change them must turn towards a direction of inclusiveness. Innovative, meaning that all functional interdependent fields of global evolution must support the forces of renewal and greater effectiveness. Liberalism, in the sense that the principles of freedom, democracy, and pluralism are still the central belief system that can bring a more equilibrated and better collective future on the planet. We believe that it is only with the practical advent of a sufficiently balanced and sustainable new phase of globalization that our world could escape the current risks of destabilization with as few losses as possible at all levels: social, economic, and political.

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